

British Shorthair

The **British Shorthair** is the pedigree version of the landrace of British domestic cat, with a distinctively stocky body, thick coat, and broad face. The most familiar colour variant is the "British Blue", with a solid grey-blue coat, copper-coloured eyes, and a medium-sized tail. The breed has also been bred in a wide range of other colours and patterns, including tabby and colourpoint.

It ranks among the oldest known cat landraces. This ancient British landrace was selectively bred into one of the first pedigreed cat breeds at the end of the 19th century, and today holds full recognition status in all major cat registries.^{[1][2]} It remains the most popular pedigree breed in its native country, as registered by the UK's Governing Council of the Cat Fancy (GCCF). Half of all kittens registered with the GCCF each year are British Shorthairs, making it the most popular pedigree cat in the UK.^[1]

The breed's relatively calm temperament makes it a frequent media star, notably as the inspiration for John Tenniel's famous illustration of the Cheshire Cat from *Alice in Wonderland*. The Cat Fanciers' Association (CFA) profile reads: "When gracelessness is observed, the British Shorthair is duly embarrassed, quickly recovering with a 'Cheshire cat smile'."^[3]

History

British Shorthair



British Shorthair female in the classic colour 'blue'.

Other names	British Blue
Origin	 <u>United Kingdom</u>
	<u>Breed standards</u>
<u>CFA</u>	standard (https://cfa.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/british-shorthair-standard.pdf)
<u>FIFe</u>	standard (http://www.fifeweb.org/dnld/std/BLH-BSH.pdf)
<u>TICA</u>	standard (https://www.tica.org/phoca/download/bs.pdf)
<u>WCF</u>	standard (https://wcf.de/pdf-en/breed/BRI_en_2021-12-30.pdf)
<u>FFE</u>	standard (https://www.bavarian-cfa.de/data/ffe/standard/britshorthair_e.htm)
<u>ACF</u>	standard (http://www.acfacat.com/Breed%20Standards/BRITISH%20SH.pdf)
<u>ACFA/CAA</u>	standard (http://www.acfacat.com/Breed%20Standards/BRITISH%20SH.pdf)

Researchers are not sure how cats first reached the British Isles. In many other parts of Europe, cats became common at the same time as the spread of the Roman Empire. However, it appears that housecats reached the British Isles before the Romans did.^[4]

These cats then interbred with the local European wildcat population. Over the centuries, their naturally isolated descendants developed into distinctively large, robust cats with a short but very thick coat, to better withstand conditions on their native islands. Based on artists' representations, the modern British Shorthair is unchanged from this initial type.^[5]



An early example of the "English type" Blue Shorthair, from Frances Simpson's *Book of the Cat*, 1903

Selective breeding of the best examples of the type began in the nineteenth century, with emphasis on developing the unusual blue-grey variant called the "British Blue" or "English type" (to distinguish it from the more fine-boned "Russian type"). Some sources directly credit UK artist and pioneering cat fancier Harrison Weir with the initial concept of standardising the breed. Others suggest a group of breeders may have been involved. The new British Shorthair was featured at the first-ever cat show, organised by Weir and held at the Crystal Palace in London in 1871, and enjoyed great initial popularity.^[6]

Cat shows

First introduced to Britain by the Romans, the British Shorthair was one of the domestic cats originally bred for its hunting prowess. In the last 150 years, breeding has emphasised physical qualities.^[7] The British Shorthair breed debuted

— along with a wide range of other selectively bred felines — in the first organised cat show arranged by Harrison Weir at London's Crystal Palace in 1871.^[4]

British Shorthairs remained the premiere pedigree at cat shows up until 1895.^[8]

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CCA-AFC

standard (https://www.cca-afc.com/documents/BreedStandards/BRITISH_20211101_225136.pdf)

GCCF

standard (<https://www.gccfcats.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/11/BSH-SOP-update.29Oct22.pdf>)

Domestic cat (*Felis catus*)



Champion black classic tabby *Xénophon* (1892-1903), a famous early British Shorthair stud

Shortly after the British Shorthair exhibit in the Crystal Palace show, the popularity of British Shorthair increased. The public began searching for breeders of British Shorthairs with various character and colour traits, all in the pursuit of "exoticness".^[9] From the late 19th century to the early 20th century, certain British Shorthairs would occasionally earn notoriety or decorated titles in Cat Competitions.^[9]

Breed development

By the 1900s with the advent of the newly imported Persian and other long-haired breeds, the British Shorthair had fallen out of favour, and breeding stock had become critically rare by World War I.^[1] At least partially to alleviate this, British Shorthair breeders mixed Persians, Russian Blue, Burmese, and Chartreux into their bloodlines.^[1] Part of the genes thus introduced would eventually become the basis for the British Longhair. At the time, any long-haired cats produced were placed into the Persian breeding program. As all cats with the blue colouration were then judged together as variants on a *de facto* single breed, the Blue Shorthair, outcrossings of the British with the Russian Blue were also common.^[5]

After the war, in an attempt to maintain the breed standard, the GCCF decided to accept only third-generation Persian x British Shorthair crosses. This contributed to another shortage of pure breeding stock by World War II, at which point the Persian and Russian Blue were reintroduced into the mix.

British Shorthair breeders also worked with the French Chartreux, another ancient breed, which although genetically unrelated to the British Blue, is very similar in appearance. Breeders worked to reestablish the true British type, and by the late 1970s the distinctive British Shorthair had achieved full recognition status from all major cat registries,^[2] including the CFA, Fédération Internationale Féline (FIFe), and The International Cat Association (TICA).^[5]



Example of modern "Champion" standard black shaded silver male

Breed registration

Popularity

The British Shorthair publicity from 19th and 20th century cat shows helped British Shorthairs become one of the most popular pet cat breeds today. For example, in the 1980s, the British Shorthair was featured in competition by the CFA, which led to an increased demand for British Shorthairs as household pets. As of 2023, the British Shorthair ranks as the 6th most popular cat breed in the United States.^[10] According to the GCCF's 2024 registry data, it is once again